



Twitter under fire

A female ex-employee of Twitter has filed a class action lawsuit against the online giant on grounds of gender discrimination <http://dgit.in/TwiSue>



Industry Connect

Step aside Tinder, Hinge has arrived

Foraying into the Indian market, dating app Hinge has launched in Mumbai, aiming to spread further soon. Digit got to chat with Justin McLeod, the founder and CEO of Hinge, and Samir Kapadia, who is leading the operations in India, on how Hinge works and also about its plans for India.



PHOTO: DEBORAH COPAKEN

Justin McLeod ►
Founder & CEO, Hinge

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A simple search on dating apps throws up an endless list of services and applications on the web and mobile, why should I choose Hinge?

Justin: We think of Hinge as the easiest way to meet the best people for you because we really in the power of meeting through your friends, especially when using social media. This technique lets you meet great people because you'll be meeting people filtered by your social network and since most people meet other people through friends in real life anyway, it's the most natural thing the world. This is very different from the anonymity that forms the basis of most other dating services.

No other dating service is as transparent and as accountable as ours. We start off with a subset of people by connecting them to people Facebook who are friends of friends and third-degree connections, people who are connected to you socially. As you use the app, we learn and understand who you are and parse out your preferences, helping us shortlist the right person for you. If you consider that an average person has 500 friends on Facebook, then you have 25,000 friends of friends and exponentially more third degree connections.

What do your stats say about the user activity on Hinge?

Justin: We have been growing really since the beginning at about 20-30% per month. We initially started in Washington DC in the US, where we launched, and then we expanded to 34 markets in the US. We are now in London and Toronto and also in Mumbai. In terms of user engagement, a typical stat is of all the people that used the app this month, over half of them used it today.

Dating apps are all the rage in India. How do you plan to compete with others?

Samir: I think that the competitive landscape is diverse, when in the past you've seen six new entrants, whether they have just come into the market or got a second round of funding, you're seeing two major trends. The first is this sort of bifurcation between matrimonial and casual encounters and dating, there have been a few that have sat in the middle finding themselves at a paradox of sorts with users but aside from that, one of the things they are doing is focusing on credibility. Having people fill out long, exhaustive forms and all of these precautionary measures that they use to ensure quality control but also to curate a good experience for women and users, we find that we don't have to do any of that. Hinge has the ability to naturally

do that by looking at your own social network. Globally when you're looking at the gender breakdown with these apps, you'll find a sort of 60:40 or 70:30 men to women ratio, Hinge takes in 50:50 and I think that's a powerful statistic. Accountability, that's built in our DNA and that's our competitive advantage.

We have observed online dating change through the years, shifting from the web to mobile. How is Hinge trying to bring a change to online dating in general?

Justin: The term online dating, is not even the same thing anymore. When Hinge and Tinder came along, we were using ambient information, so we were using either your Facebook social graph or your current location and we were using that information to introduce you to people in a really lightweight way. And I think that really changed the paradigm for so called online dating because it is so easy, why wouldn't you do it? So, no longer is it a service for desperate people, it's for anyone and I think that really helped break down the stigma. The only remaining stigma is really just legacy left over from the Match.com and OkCupid days. So, I think we are at the forefront at bringing down the barrier and I think it's only apps that makes the process as easy, ambient and tied into your real life as something like Hinge that are actually removing the stigma. **d**